

RISE OF THE MACHINES

“IT CAN’T BE BARGAINED WITH. IT CAN’T BE REASONED WITH. IT DOESN’T FEEL PITY, OR REMORSE, OR FEAR. AND IT ABSOLUTELY WILL NOT STOP, EVER, UNTIL YOU ARE DEAD.” – JOHN CONNOR

BY **ANIRUDH REGIDI**

Despite your fears of a robot apocalypse, you have to admit that you’re secretly hoping for one. Call it what you will, a sick fascination or an unhealthy obsession. While AI is still only software, intangible, a robot is its physical manifestation. It is a tangible entity, the physical extension of an AI, something that will appeal to our innate anthropomorphic tendencies.

True, sentient AI may not yet exist, but we’re definitely doing our bit to ensure that when it does, it will have a body to command. Till that happens however, let’s take a look at some of the modern milestones in the history of robotics.

ATLAS

Cyberdyne exists, and it’s called Boston Dynamics. If the birth of the Terminator in the movies was heralded by his arm, the birth of the real life Terminator will be heralded by a leg, and it’s attached to the ATLAS robot.

Boston Dynamics has spent many years working on ATLAS, a bipedal robot that has finally been endowed with the ability to walk, run, jump and traverse a wide variety of obstacles. What’s the need for such a robot you ask? Ostensibly, to test hazard suits. Hah! It won’t be long before someone sticks a gun on that thing and sends it on its first counter-insurgency mission. Imagine an army of these backed by ferocious BigDogs (more on that later!)

Robots have had the ability to walk for quite some time, Asimo being a prime example, but they’ve never been really

good at it. ATLAS is not like that. With 28 hydraulic joints capable of replicating almost the entire range of human motion and backed by a LIDAR (light-based ranging), stereo cameras. For now, ATLAS is nothing more than a shell that needs to be hooked up to a rig and an external computer and power unit to function, but with Elon Musk pushing for powerful batteries and quantum computers just around the corner, how long do you think it’ll be before you’ll see an army of ATLAS bots (Atli?) patrolling our streets?

BIGDOG

Did we mention that Boston Dynamics is Cyberdyne? Well, they’re already going beyond SkyNet’s “humanoid” terminators and went ahead and created the scariest dog on the planet. Unimaginatively



Wildcat: killing you loudly, and quickly

christened “BigDog”, 3 feet long, 2.5 feet tall and weighing in at just a little over 100kgs, this is one hell of a dog.

As with ATLAS, BigDog has ostensibly been designed to work as a pack mule that is capable of carrying a load of around 150kgs and following a soldier around the battlefield (as any good dog should). It’s “dynamically stable” meaning that there’s very little that can phase it on its journey and because of that, is rightly called the most advanced rough-terrain robot on Earth.

Right now, BigDog can only manage a top speed of 6kph, making it easy to simply outwalk. But Boston Dynamics has yet another ace up its sleeve in the form of the WildCat. (Damn you, Boston Dynamics!)

WILDCAT

Imagine this: your unit is just barely managing to hold off a wave of Atlas bots (which are supported by a virtually unlimited supply of ammo and spares provided by a small army of BigDogs). Your back is against the wall, but you know that you can hold out till backup arrives... and then you hear it. That dreaded whine. Your unit panics, starts looking around desperately for the source of the new threat, knowing that it’s already too late. The whine intensifies, the ground starts to rumble. You take a deep breath, line up your crosshairs on the bushes behind you, where the whine seems to be the strongest and then, BOOM! Before you know it they’re upon you! Four legged monstrosities that came charging through the bushes at a little over 60kph, knocking